

Her story underscores that growing in your career is not only about ambition, it also depends on having the right support around you.

This gap becomes even more visible mid-career, a point at which experience collides with exhaustion. Saundarya Rajesh, Founder-President, Avtar Group, a workplace culture consulting firm, notes that this “mid-career cliff” is intensifying in the AI era. “Nearly 60% of women now require urgent upskilling to stay competitive in an AI-driven workplace, yet targeted learning opportunities often bypass them.”

### HEALTH: AN INVISIBLE BARRIER

Menstruation, fertility treatments, perimenopause, and menopause create health realities that significantly impact women’s working lives, yet workplaces still treat them as private struggles. Parikh shares: “IVF was demanding. I took work calls even when completely under the weather.” Many women quietly push through severe discomfort: Deloitte reports that 40% work through intense symptoms without taking time off, and one in ten say talking about menstrual challenges negatively affected their career.

Fertility, IVF cycles, and menopausal symptoms also affect confidence and performance. Rohit Jetley, Head of Global Platform Solutions Delivery and India Site Head, Fidelity International, stresses that organisations must act: “Menstrual health is not just personal, it’s a workplace wellbeing issue.” Recently, Karnataka became the first Indian state to offer paid menstrual leaves to all working women in formal jobs.

### THE EVERYDAY BIAS

Despite years of progress, gender bias remains one of the deepest, most stubborn barriers to women’s advancement. It appears in hiring, promotions, pay, and daily interactions, often subtly, but powerfully.

Sharon has seen it repeatedly. “Men are trusted more with delivery. They bond easily with the boys’ club. Women, especially mothers, are sidelined.” What widens the gap further is access to informal networks.

Rajesh notes this is systemic, not anecdotal. “In our January 2025 study on gender diversity in the C-suite, 44% of women identified bias in hiring and promotion as a persistent challenge, and nearly half—48%—said organisational culture itself acts as a barrier,” she says. Work-life pressures compound this, with 60% of women citing it as a major obstacle to senior roles.

Contrary to stereotypes, women today are equally career-driven. The BCWI 2025 study found that “seeking better job opportunities” is the top reason both men and



**“Mid-career attrition among women is not new, but the advent of AI and rapid technological change has exacerbated the trend”**

**SAUNDARYA RAJESH**  
FOUNDER-PRESIDENT, AVTAR GROUP



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**NEHA BAGARIA**  
FOUNDER AND CEO, HERKEY

women quit. And the Avtar-EY GDS study, *Why We Work*, | 161 shows women are even more adaptable and future-ready (57% women versus 52% men).

Yet the pay gap remains stark. Global UN and WEF data show women still earn significantly less, with gaps widening in managerial roles. Rajesh emphasises structural action: “Regular pay audits, clear compensation frameworks, and active sponsorship are crucial. Mentorship isn’t enough; leaders must become sponsors who advocate for women at decision-making tables.”

Bias also lives in quieter experiences—microaggressions and non-inclusive behaviours that chip away at confidence. Deloitte research shows 34% of women faced non-inclusive behaviours in the past year, with microaggressions reported by 28%. Only 58% of women who face microaggressions speak up. Many fear being labelled “too sensitive” or believe “nothing will change.”

Rewriting the narrative begins with rejecting the myth of perfect balance. What sustains women’s careers isn’t flawless multitasking but the presence of strong support systems.

While women have to meander around multitudes of obstacles—lack of support at home, gender bias working against them, predatory workplace, or a hostile working environment, Bagaria’s final reminder carries both steel and pragmatism: “We can’t wait for knights in shining armour. Women must be their own knights.” **BT**